

Syllabus for COMP 170-001, Introduction to Object-Oriented Programming

This course is an introduction to the computer science major, covering basic concepts using the Python object-oriented (OO) programming language. The course addresses the following questions: What is an algorithm? How does one write, debug, run (“execute”), and test an effective computer program? How does one convert an algorithm into a computer program? How does one judge a program? What does “object-oriented” mean?

Topics include variables, data types, input/output, loops and repetition, choice, lists, subprograms, classes/objects, basic OO principles, and possibly recursion. This course is programming intensive. Lab sessions will be held during class periods.

NOTE: This Syllabus and the course schedule are subject to change; changes will be announced in advance in class and posted on Sakai.

Class sessions, schedule, are Section-dependent (all are primarily Lab sessions). See the COMP 170 project site for the details of the schedule: the **Sakai → Syllabus** item contains this Syllabus and also shows a weekly overview of topics. Sakai has a “Week n” tab as the starting point for all materials and assignments for the week.

NOTE: All COMP 170 sections will use a common Sakai project site in Spring 2026, [COMP 170 SP26](#), not the official course sites for those sections – click that link to navigate to the common course site.

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Prerequisites

Math 117 with C- grade or better or placement into more advanced math course. No prior programming experience is required but will be very helpful. The logical mindset of mathematics is generally helpful in learning programming.

Special Course Requirements

1. COMP 170 is a programming intensive course. Considerable time will be spent creating programs in the lab sessions and outside class. The largest portion of your grade will be determined by your success in writing, compiling, running, and testing these programs.
2. The course may include some programming assignments done with another person (“Pair Programming”) or small teams of 2 to 6 students (“Team Programming”).
3. The course uses Sakai to organize materials. You will generally submit your assignments using Sakai. Ask for help if you are not familiar with Sakai.
4. The course may use Zoom or some other online connection software for additional online sessions.

Textbooks (required)

We will use Pearson's **Building Python Programs, 1st Edition (BPP)**, by Stuart Reges, Marty Stepp, and Allison Obourn as the primary COMP 170 textbook. You should acquire the textbook before the first week of class if at all possible. Class Labs and homework will be based on this textbook as well as other material that will be provided; **you will not be able to complete most homework assignments unless you have access to the textbook.**

How to purchase this textbook for COMP 170: go to [Pearson.com](https://www.pearson.com), create an account if you do not have one already, and search for Building Python Programs, 1st Edition.

- **You can rent the textbook for one semester (actually 6 months) for \$8.49 monthly**
 - The 6-month version has ISBN 9780137530731.

Note: if you need to use Ramblerbucks to purchase your textbook please contact your instructor.

In addition to the course textbook there are exercises that you will do in a required online tool called CodeStepByStep (Code SxS); here are instructions for how to connect to that tool before the course starts:

- Access Code SxS at <https://www.codestepbystep.com/> using up to the first 10 characters in your Loyola UVID and the initial password that is supplied by your faculty in the Sakai course Overview - **please change that password the first time you access Code SxS.** Code SxS is required for COMP 170, and you should be automatically enrolled in it before the first day of class; if you do not have access by then please use this form to alert us about the problem:
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSdEOBGrCshOmV2xMh1hC5_YB5Os5PB3A5CGfXIr08oYlv5QA/viewform?usp=publish-editor.

Course Objectives and Goals

Upon successful completion of the course, the student will be able to:

1. Write good Python programs of small to medium size – programs that are correct, high quality, and use correct and appropriate basic Object Oriented Programming (OOP) techniques.
2. Reuse Python programs and modules as well as Application Programming Interfaces (APIs) developed by others, especially the standard Python APIs.
3. Understand and recognize proper programming style and demonstrate making design decisions consistent with Object Oriented methodologies.
4. Be able to read, understand, and interpret Python programs written by others.

Software

You will need to install Python on your personal PC or laptop (not a tablet or phone) and download a set of files for this course. There is a Panopto video showing how to do this for a Windows PC or a Mac as part of the required pre-class activities. You will need to complete these steps before the first week of class.

Academic Honesty

Students are expected to have read the statement on academic integrity available at http://www.luc.edu/academics/catalog/undergrad/reg_academicintegrity.shtml. This policy applies to the course. The minimum penalty for academic dishonesty is a grade of F for that assignment. Multiple instances or a single severe instance on a major exam or assignment may result in a grade of F for the course. All cases of academic dishonesty will be reported to the department office and the relevant college office where they will be placed in your school record.

Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, working together on assignments that are not group assignments, copying or sharing assignments or exam information with other students except in group assignments, submitting as your own information from current or former students of this course, copying information from anywhere on the web and submitting it as your own work, and submitting anything as your own work which you have not personally created for this course. **If you do wish to use materials that are not your own, please check**

with your instructor ahead of time and cite your source clearly. When in doubt, ask first! Be aware that we may have changed the values for many of the textbook problems that are used for homework problems. For those problems that require open-ended answers, please be very careful to state the answers in your own words, not in the words of the Instructor's Manual, nor in the words of students who have previously taken this course.

Note: Course materials cannot be shared outside the course without your instructor's written permission.

The use of Chegg, ChatGPT, or any other online help, including reviewing YouTube videos, to solve homework or exam problems is not allowed! You may use them only for guidance and to understand concepts. You are allowed to collaborate on in-class Lab exercises, but you may not jointly develop homework or exam problem answers.

Generative AI Usage (eg, ChatGPT)

Gaining fluency in a programming language requires a fair amount of trial/error and the process is often uncomfortable for many at first. This sentiment is perfectly normal and should be embraced as part of the learning process. COMP 170 is a foundational course in computer science with a major goal of obtaining fluency in using the Python programming language. As a result, students are discouraged from using generative AI as a primary means of obtaining solutions for Lab exercises and homework problems.

While using AI to answer software problems can appear to save time, it can also inhibit key learning in areas such as logical / computational thinking, abstraction, and problem solving. You are encouraged to use generative AI to obtain hints and guidance for exercises, but if you do, you are required to cite which tool was used and submit an evaluation of the answers the AI tool proposes, both in terms of accuracy and correctness and the logical approach the tool is using. Any such assignment may have its score lowered based on use of AI to solve the assignment. Your instructors can usually detect the use of AI to solve a problem based on your previous work and how different an AI solution is in terms of sophistication and use of unusual programming approaches.

Just like use of Chegg, etc, use of generative AI is strictly forbidden on all course quizzes and exams.

Lateness Policy

Students who arrive in the first 10 minutes or so of class are generally treated as attending the entire class. Note that class attendance and participation do contribute to your overall course grade.

Online Recording Policy

In this class software may be used to record live class discussions. As a student in this class, your participation in live class discussions may be recorded. These recordings will be made available only to students enrolled in the class, to assist those who cannot attend the live session or to serve as a resource for those who would like to review content that was presented. All recordings will become unavailable to students in the class when the Sakai course is unpublished (i.e. shortly after the course ends, per the Sakai administrative schedule:

<https://www.luc.edu/its/sakai/sakaiadministrativeschedule/>).

In cases where an online session is recorded, students who prefer to participate via audio only will be allowed to disable their video camera so only audio will be captured. Please discuss this option with your professor. The use of all video recordings will be in keeping with the University Privacy Statement shown [below](#):

Privacy Statement

Assuring privacy among faculty and students engaged in online and face-to-face instructional activities helps promote open and robust conversations and mitigates concerns that comments made within the context of the class will be shared beyond the classroom. As such, recordings of instructional activities occurring in online or face-to-face classes may be used solely for internal class purposes by the faculty member and students registered for the course, and only during the period in which the course is offered. Students will be informed of such recordings by a statement in the syllabus for the course in which they will be recorded. Instructors who wish to make subsequent use of recordings that include student activity may do so only with informed written consent of the students involved or if all student activity is removed from the recording. Recordings including student activity that have been initiated by the instructor may be retained by the instructor only for individual use.

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Religious Holidays

If you need to miss class for a religious holiday, please alert your instructor in advance so that will not be counted as an absence. As needed, conflicting due dates for quizzes and tests, homework, and Lab assignments can be adjusted.

Students with Disabilities

Loyola University provides reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities. Any student requesting accommodations related to a disability or other condition is required to register with Student Accessibility Center (SAC), located in Sullivan Center, Suite 117. Students will provide professors with an accommodation notification from SAC, preferably within the first two weeks of class. Students are encouraged to meet with their professor individually in order to discuss their accommodations. All information will remain confidential. Please note that in this class, software may be used to record class lectures in order to provide equal access to students with disabilities. Students approved for this accommodation use recordings for their personal study only and recordings may not be shared with other people or used in any way against the faculty member, other lecturers, or students whose classroom comments are recorded as part of the class activity. Recordings are deleted at the end of the semester. For more information about registering with SAC or questions about accommodations, please contact SAC at 773-508-3700 or SAC@luc.edu. **Note: students who are allowed to take their exams at the SAC office are encouraged to do so. *Should you choose to take an exam in the classroom, we cannot guarantee that the classroom environment will be quiet enough to provide you with the environment that your disability may require. If you choose to take the exam in the classroom, you will be taking that risk. If you cannot access the SAC office because of any continuing pandemic restrictions we can make the exams available for you to take online.***

Students with Sponsorships and Scholarships

If you require a certain grade in order to satisfy a sponsor or a scholarship requirement, please be sure to monitor your grade on Sakai. We will consider only your performance in this course in calculating grades, using the grading rubric posted in this syllabus. If you cannot achieve a minimum grade that is required by a sponsor or a scholarship, we will not change your grade to help you meet that requirement. This would be unfair to other students, and not reflective of your performance in this course. You are responsible to monitor your grade and to keep apprised of the [withdrawal dates](#) posted by the registrar.

Course Components and Grading

Your grade will consist of several components with relative weights as follows (I reserve the right to adjust the percentages in **your favor** if circumstances warrant). See in addition the sections on Religious Holidays (above), Timely Completion (below), and Academic Honesty (above).

1. Homework Assignments (Sakai Assignments – 20%) typically due Sunday each week. These are Python assignments throughout the course. You will write, run, and test your program before turning it in. **Programs that do not successfully compile without errors will usually receive a failing grade.**
2. Lab Assignments (Code SxS – 15%). The lab assignments will be primarily completed during class sessions by Thursday night and will be reviewed by your instructor and/or the course TA(s) for credit.
3. Quizzes and Examinations (40%). Any quizzes plus 3 to 4 examination scores. A pop quiz may be given in one of the class sessions at any time without prior notice; it may cover any topic in the course to date. This approach serves to encourage you to keep up-to-date on readings and lecture material. There will be no “make-up” quizzes or exams unless you have made prior arrangements with your instructor to be excused from them. These items typically open Thursday and are due Saturday night. One of the exams will be a course final exam during finals week of the semester.
4. Final Project (20%). There will be a final team programming project for the course that includes periodic progress reports and a final team class presentation during one of the class sessions in the final week of the class; details will be provided in the future. **This project is in addition to the final exam!**
5. Participation (5%). Students are expected to review all online lecture material prior to classes and attend all class sessions for the full time period. The participation grade will be based upon attendance and enthusiastic involvement and contributions to discussions in the class sessions, and contributions to the course Discussion Forum (see below). Attendance will be taken for all class sessions.

- **If you have a class attendance or assignment submission conflict due to a Religious Holiday, family emergency, athletic schedule, or sickness, please contact your instructor about your conflict as soon as you can, ideally before the conflicting date.**

All course work will be graded numerically, and your letter grade will be determined from total points earned, weighted as above. Your total points will be converted to a letter grade using **approximately** the following percentage ranges. Calculations will generally round fractional percentages below .500 down to the full number less than that value, and round percentages at .500 and above up to the full number above that value. We will maintain the grade percentages and letter grades on Sakai consistent with your ongoing performance and visible to you, so you can use Sakai to determine how you are doing in this course at any time.

93-100 = A	90-92 = A-	
87-89 = B+	82-86 = B	79-81 = B-
74-78 = C+	68-73 = C	62-67 = C-
56-61 = D+	50-55 = D	
49 and lower = F		

If for any reason you do miss a class session, it is your responsibility to determine what you missed, locate any handouts, determine any changes in assignments, course plans, or schedules, etc. It is not our obligation to help you make up for missing class. We will not always cover all information from the online course material and textbooks in class; additional materials may be added, and additional guidance will be given. Information and activities in class and labs that are not in the books will likely appear on exams and quizzes and will be helpful for your assignments and programming projects.

Please do not ask for personal “extra credit” to improve your grade as this is neither practical in the course nor fair to your fellow students. We reserve the right to provide extra credit assignments for the entire class if appropriate. Your instructor or TA will be happy to discuss your performance in the course with you at any time, including discussing your possible grade based on current performance plus ways to improve your performance during the remainder of the course. In fact, we encourage you to arrange time to talk with your instructor or TA outside of class if you have any questions regarding the topics we have covered in the course, homework, quizzes and exams, etc.

Course Schedule

The specific course schedule with weekly topics, reading assignments, labs, and homework are in the common Sakai project site. Start with the “Week” Lesson for a list of the full week’s topics and activities. Please see **Sakai → Syllabus** for an overview of the whole semester. These schedule materials are an integral part of this syllabus. Please ask if you have any questions about what is due and what you should be doing. The Sakai Calendar also lists items that are due on any particular day of the course; that Calendar is visible on the course Overview webpage.

Please note that the official Academic Calendar, found here: www.luc.edu/academics/schedules, has information about all Loyola breaks, the final exam schedules, and other relevant schedule information.

Professor Notes

Timely Completion

You are expected to complete all assignments, readings, video reviews, and projects on time. In computer systems in the “real world” there is always a strong emphasis on getting projects done on time. Use this class to develop your own skills at timely completion. It is your responsibility to know course due dates and complete assignments, etc, based on those due dates.

Personal and any team programming projects and other assignments will be due as described at the time of the assignment. See the class schedule for advanced planning.

Late assignment submission is **strongly** discouraged, but there are some available options on the next page.

1. **Each student will be allowed up to TWO (2) late assignments of their choice.** Think of this as having two “Late OK” passes. These passes may be used for lab sessions, programming, and non-programming assignments (not for quizzes or exams). Late Passes allow you to turn in an assignment up to 48 hours after the due date. Use Sakai’s **Late Pass 1** and **2** assignments at the bottom of the Sakai Assignments webpage to submit material for late assignments or to alert your instructor and TAs that you have completed a late set of CodeStepByStep Lab exercises.
2. Except in case of emergencies agreed to with your instructor, no assignments will be accepted after the due date unless you are using one of your late passes and the assignment is turned in within 48 hours of the original date. Once your two Late Passes are used up no more assignments will be accepted after the due date. There are no exceptions except for documented emergencies.
3. Assignments are generally submitted in Sakai (Lab exercises are completed in CodeStepByStep). Please plan ahead and be sure you complete the submission of the assignment on time. Also note that you can Save assignment materials on Sakai as many times as you want, but once you click Submit you may not be able to change your submission.

You are welcome to ask questions on all assignments and course work, seek additional information on the assignments, and offer observations on the assignments either in or outside of class. There will be a common class Discussion Forum in the Sakai project site – this will allow students from different sections to ask and answer questions and raise issues that will likely be common across all COMP 170 sections.

Please plan your work ahead and do not wait for the last minute to begin work! **Complete the assignments before the due date to make sure your answers will compile and run!** This step will be key to your success in class. **No sympathy given for procrastination!**

Sakai Grading Feedback

Be sure to read your grading comments in Sakai regularly. These comments are there to help you learn.

Questions on grades are welcome. However, to encourage timely review of grading notes (see immediately above), no changes will be made beyond 2 weeks after the comments are posted.

Office Hours and Help

Office hours are listed in the common Sakai project site Overview, and we may post additional hours later in the semester. We may also provide planned times for online interactions with the instructor or TA(s) and other students (also see the discussion forum information below). Additional times are usually available by appointment, and we encourage you to set up times to talk with us and the TAs about the course, questions you have, etc.

The Department of Computer Science provides tutors for this and other courses; you can find information about tutors on the CS website at <http://luc.edu/cs/people/tutors/>.

The common course Discussion Forum, accessible in the Sakai Project site, is available for additional help. The discussion forum will allow the exchange of student ideas as well as online interactions with your instructors, TAs, and other students. You are encouraged to use this Forum to ask questions and provide helpful hints to other students across all the sections of the course; however, you may not ask for the answer to a specific lab exercise or homework assignment, and you may not provide that kind of answer directly. We will monitor the Forum for questions and issues, so do be careful about what you post there. **Note that Forum participation is part of your overall course grade.**

Class lecture slides and links to video recordings of lectures will be available online on Sakai. Assignments will also be available on Sakai, with Lab exercises in the CodeStepByStep tool. We expect you to review all class material and any video recordings in advance, to attend all class sessions, and to take notes on course material as appropriate before, during, and after the class sessions.

We will let you know before all our course exams what information will be covered in each and what material you can have access to during those exams. There may also be practice exams.

Gender Misconduct Mandatory Reporting

Loyola University Chicago faculty are committed to supporting our students and upholding gender equity laws as outlined by Title IX. Therefore, if a student chooses to confide in a member of Loyola's faculty or staff regarding an issue of gender-based misconduct, that faculty or staff member is obligated to tell Loyola's Title IX Deputy Coordinator. The Title IX Deputy Coordinator will assist the student in connecting with all possible resources for support and reporting both on and off campus.

Continuous Improvement

We believe in a personal quality process of continuous improvement. Anything can be improved by applying the quality process of "Plan, Do, Check, Act" (PDCA). To improve the course and the learning of programming, Python, and computer science concepts, we welcome your feedback, comments, suggestions, and complaints at any time.

In support of this PDCA process above, we may ask you to participate in surveys and discussions during the course. These surveys will measure student impressions of the course; when time permits, we will share the results with the class. Your inputs on these surveys are anonymous and in no way affect your grade.

We will also be using an LUC feedback system called SmartEvals plus a Google survey toward the end of the course to gather your feedback on both the course itself and our teaching; We use this feedback to improve how we teach the information in the course, and the CS Department uses it to help refresh and improve our course offerings.

Comp170 Syllabus v14 (minor edits) November 2025

Comp170 Syllabus v13 (minor edits) August 2025

Comp170 Syllabus v12 (updated for use of the Python programming language) November 2024

Comp170 Syllabus v11 (minor edits) December 2023

Comp170 Syllabus v10 (addition of restrictions on using Generative AI (eg, ChatGPT) for Lab and homework assignments) August 2023